

The Cold War: A Global Ideological Struggle

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History

Geopolitics

Cold War

20th Century

CUES	NOTES
1. What policy did President Truman establish in 1947 to counter Soviet expansion?	1. The Truman Doctrine committed US economic and military aid to nations threatened by communist expansion, beginning with Greece and Turkey. It established the principle of containment that guided American foreign policy for the next four decades, fundamentally reshaping the global balance of power.
2. How did the Marshall Plan reshape post-war Europe economically?	2. The Marshall Plan injected over \$13 billion into Western European economies between 1948 and 1952, rebuilding industrial infrastructure and stabilizing democratic governments. It created lasting economic ties between the US and Europe while deliberately excluding Soviet-aligned states from participation.
3. What was the significance of the Berlin Wall erected in 1961?	3. The Berlin Wall physically divided East and West Berlin for 28 years, becoming the most potent symbol of the Iron Curtain. Its construction halted a mass exodus of skilled workers from East Germany, with over 140 documented deaths of people attempting to cross it during its existence.
4. How close did the Cuban Missile Crisis bring the world to nuclear war in October 1962?	4. During 13 days in October 1962, the discovery of Soviet nuclear missiles in Cuba triggered the most dangerous confrontation of the Cold War. President Kennedy imposed a naval blockade while secret negotiations with Khrushchev ultimately led to Soviet missile withdrawal in exchange for a US pledge not to invade Cuba.
5. What role did the Strategic Defense Initiative play in ending the Cold War?	5. President Reagan's Strategic Defense Initiative, announced in 1983, proposed a space-based missile defense system that would render nuclear weapons obsolete. Though technologically ambitious, SDI exerted enormous economic pressure on the Soviet Union, which could not match the required spending.
6. Which event in 1991 formally marked the dissolution of the Soviet Union?	6. On December 25, 1991, Mikhail Gorbachev resigned as Soviet president, and the Soviet flag was lowered over the Kremlin for the last time. The 15 constituent republics became independent nations, ending 74 years of communist rule and the Cold War's bipolar world order.

SUMMARY

The Cold War (1947-1991) was a defining geopolitical struggle between the United States and the Soviet Union that shaped the modern world without direct military confrontation between the superpowers. Through proxy wars, nuclear brinkmanship, economic competition, and ideological contests, both sides sought global influence. Key turning points — from the Truman Doctrine and Marshall Plan through the Cuban Missile Crisis and SDI — demonstrate how the conflict evolved from military containment to economic and technological competition, ultimately contributing to the Soviet Union's dissolution and the emergence of a unipolar world order.